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TRIALS AND LIARS

RIGHT AFTER the tour in England against Australia, I was called back for the next series – this time against England. I remember I was at Karachi Airport with Abdul Razzaq when I heard about the *News of the World* sting operation unfold.

Both Razzaq and I were standing at the immigration counter, just blankly staring at each other, while all of this was beginning to unravel as breaking news on TV sets all over the airport.

'I told you so, Lala,' said Razzaq to me. He himself was in shock.

'You did. You sure did,' I responded. It was an admission and I didn't want to let him down further about how the management hadn't listened to my warnings. I didn't sleep much on that flight. I was trying to imagine how bad things would be when I reached England.

After our flight landed, I didn't even bother checking in at the hotel. Instead, I went straight to the three accused: Salman Butt, Mohammad Asif and Mohammad Amir. Butt and Asif were up, in the former's room, visibly worried. Amir was passed out on the hotel bed. I asked them how they were doing.

Salman responded: 'Lala, they are trying to trap us. They want us to be scapegoats in all of this.'

I chose not to confront him, because I didn't want to be too harsh on him, considering what he was already going through. I asked him if there was anything more he was worried about. When he flatly denied all the accusations hurled by *News of the World*, I turned around and pointed to Amir and said, 'Well, you should be like him then. He doesn't seem to have a worry in the world. Go on. Get some rest.'

By the time I left the room, I knew. I could tell from their eyes – they were lying.

From thereon, the tour became hell. As captain, it was especially bad. Nothing was working out. Though just three of the guys were named in the exposé, the issue wasn't just about them. It was about all of us, the entire Pakistan camp. It was about the country, actually.

We were admonished as a unit. We were shown the finger everywhere we went. People said